English Class

# HALLOWEEN

*Origins, customs and language of the spookiest night of the year*









# WARM-UP



Why do so many people enjoy being scared?



Is Halloween becoming too commercialized?



What happens to a tradition when it crosses borders?

# WHERE IT ALL BEGAN

Halloween traces back to **Samhain**, an ancient Celtic festival held around 31 October in Ireland, Scotland and Britain.

It marked the end of the harvest and the start of the dark half of the year, when the boundary between the living and the dead was believed to blur.

People lit bonfires and wore disguises to ward off wandering spirits.



# FROM SAMHAIN TO HALLOWEEN

### c. 2,000 years ago

Celts celebrate Samhain, marking the shift to winter.

### 9th century

The Church sets All Saints' Day on 1 November; the eve becomes All Hallows' Eve.

### 19th century

Irish immigrants carry their customs to the United States.

### 20th century to today

Trick-or-treating and costume parties go mainstream; the festival goes global.

# CUSTOMS AND TRADITIONS



## Jack-o'-lanterns

Inspired by an Irish legend, the first were carved from turnips. In America, pumpkins took over.



## Trick-or-treating

Rooted in "souling" and "guising", children now go door to door asking for sweets.



## Costumes

Once worn to disguise oneself from spirits, now a chance to play a character.



## Parties and games

Bonfires, haunted attractions and games such as bobbing for apples.

# AROUND THE WORLD

## Ireland
The birthplace of the festival: bonfires, parties and apple games.

## Mexico
Día de Muertos (1-2 November) is a different tradition: it honours the dead with altars and marigolds.

## Japan
Large costume gatherings, especially in Tokyo, show how the festival has been adapted locally.

## Brazil
Not a native tradition, but popular in schools, parties and language classes. 31 October is also Dia do Saci.

# ADVANCED VOCABULARY

**eerie**
strange and frightening in a quiet way

**folklore**
traditional stories and beliefs of a community

**superstition**
a belief not based on reason or science

**macabre**
disturbing because it involves death

**apparition**
a ghost or ghostlike image

**to haunt**
to appear repeatedly in a place or in one's mind

**bonfire**
a large outdoor fire

**ward off**
to keep something harmful away

# SPOOKY IDIOMS

**a skeleton in the closet : a shameful secret**
*Every family seems to have a skeleton in the closet.*

**scared stiff : extremely frightened**
*I was scared stiff during the film.*

**to jump out of your skin : to be suddenly shocked**
*The noise made me jump out of my skin.*

**to give someone the creeps : to make someone feel uneasy**
*That old house gives me the creeps.*

**a ghost of a chance : a very slim chance**
*He doesn't have a ghost of a chance of winning.*

# SPECULATING ABOUT THE PAST

Use **modal + have + past participle** to make deductions about past events.

**MUST HAVE + past participle** (almost certain)

**Someone must have left the window open.**

**MIGHT / COULD HAVE + past participle** (possible)

**It might have been the wind.**

**CAN'T / COULDN'T HAVE + past participle** (impossible)

**It can't have been a ghost. Ghosts aren't real!**

# FORM

Structure

**subject + modal + have + past participle**

| | |
|---|---|
| **Affirmative** | **She must have seen a ghost.** |
| **Negative** | **He can't have heard it. / They might not have noticed.** |
| **Question** | **Could it have been a bat?** |

Tip: the opposite of **must have** is **can't have**, not "mustn't have". Avoid *must* in questions: use *could* or "Do you think...?".

# PRESENT VS PAST

## PRESENT / NOW

modal + base verb

**She must be scared.**

**He might be hiding.**

**It can't be real.**

## PAST

modal + have + past participle

**She must have been scared.**

**He might have hidden.**

**It can't have been real.**

**Continuous: must have been + verb-ing**

**They must have been waiting for hours.**

# PRONUNCIATION

In natural speech, **have** is weak and sounds like "uv". That is why many learners write *of* by mistake.

| Full form | Contracted | Sounds like |
|---|---|---|
| must have | must've | MUS-tuv |
| might have | might've | MY-tuv |
| could have | could've | KUD-uv |
| couldn't have | couldn't've | KUD-nt-uv |

Repeat after me

**It must've been a ghost!**

# COMMON MISTAKES

✕ It must had been a bat.

✓ **It must have been a bat.**

After a modal, use have + past participle.

✕ It must of been the wind.

✓ **It must have / must've been the wind.**

"of" is a misspelling of the sound of 've.

✕ She mustn't have seen it.

✓ **She can't have seen it.**

Use can't have for "impossible".

✕ Must it have been a ghost?

✓ **Could it have been a ghost?**

Avoid must in questions.

# PRACTICE 1: COMPLETE

Use must have, might have or can't have. The tag shows how sure you are.

**1.** (impossible) The door was locked from the inside, so the thief _____ (come) through it.

**2.** (sure) There are wet footprints on the floor. Someone _____ (walk) in recently.

**3.** (possible) I'm not sure who called me. It _____ (be) my cousin.

**4.** (sure) The candy bowl is empty and the kids are smiling. They _____ (eat) it all.

**5.** (impossible) The ghost _____ (open) the window. Ghosts aren't real!

# PRACTICE 2: REWRITE

Rewrite each sentence with a modal of deduction. Keep the same meaning.

1. I'm sure the guests left early.
2. Perhaps it was a bat.
3. It's impossible that she saw a ghost.
4. I'm certain he forgot his costume.
5. Maybe they got lost in the forest.

# GRAMMAR ANSWERS

**Practice 1**

1. can't have come
2. must have walked
3. might have been
4. must have eaten
5. can't have opened

**Practice 2**

1. The guests must have left early.
2. It might / could have been a bat.
3. She can't have seen a ghost.
4. He must have forgotten his costume.
5. They might / could have got lost in the forest.

# MYSTERY: THE HAUNTED CABIN

**What you found:**

- A cup of tea, still warm
- Muddy footprints at the door
- A window broken from the inside
- A diary with the last page torn out



In pairs, speculate about what happened using must have, might have and can't have.

# DEBATE

**Halloween has become more about business than tradition.**

**Adopting foreign festivals weakens local culture.**

**Useful language**

I'd argue that...

On the one hand... on the other...

That said, ...

I see your point, but...

# QUICK QUIZ

1. What did Samhain mark?
2. Where does the name "Halloween" come from?
3. What were the first jack-o'-lanterns made from?
4. Which group helped bring these customs to the United States?
5. Complete: The door was locked, so someone _____ (have) a key.

# QUIZ ANSWERS

1. The end of the harvest and the start of the dark half of the year.
2. "All Hallows' Eve", the evening before All Saints' Day.
3. Turnips.
4. Irish immigrants.
5. must have had

# HAPPY HALLOWEEN!

**Homework: write a 120-word paragraph comparing Halloween with a tradition from Brazil. Use at least 4 words from today's vocabulary.**

